SkillNavora

MASTER HANDBOOK

Salesforce Marketing Cloud: the complete handbook

All 28 modules with every topic, the product naming notes and the practical lab list.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Start here

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) is a platform for email, mobile, journeys and automation. Marketing Cloud Engagement is the product most SFMC developers and administrators work in. Related Salesforce products (Marketing Cloud Personalization, Marketing Cloud Intelligence, Data Cloud and editions such as Growth and Advanced) have their own names, licences and features. Check every product, edition and feature on Salesforce's official pages before you promise it to a customer.

How to learn with this handbook

1. Read the module, then the topic, in order.
2. Do the exercise on paper or with sample files.
3. Use an SFMC sandbox or test business unit for labs marked "account".
4. Answer the interview question out loud.

Module 1: CRM and Digital Marketing Fundamentals

Level: Beginner. What CRM and digital marketing are, the customer lifecycle, channels and the metrics every campaign is judged on.

Module 1

1.1 CRM and the customer lifecycle

WHAT IS IT?

> A CRM (customer relationship management) system stores customers, their interactions and their history. The lifecycle runs from first awareness to acquisition, onboarding, engagement, retention and re-engagement.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Marketing automation only works when the customer data and lifecycle stage are right. Most campaign mistakes come from wrong audiences, not wrong emails.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. List the lifecycle stages for your product (for example: visitor, lead, customer, active, lapsed).
2. For each stage, write one message and one goal.
3. Map each stage to the data you need (sign-up date, last purchase, last open).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A bank: a visitor who applies for a card moves to lead; approval makes them a customer; no transaction for 90 days starts a re-engagement journey.

COMMON ERRORS

Mixing up lead and customer, so a paying customer gets an acquisition offer.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain the customer lifecycle and one message for each stage.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the lifecycle for an online course business with five stages and the data field that marks each stage.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 1

1.2 Channels and marketing metrics

WHAT IS IT?

> Digital channels include email, SMS, push notifications, web and social media, plus paid advertising. Key metrics: open rate, click-through rate, click-to-open rate, conversion rate, bounce rate, unsubscribe rate and revenue per send.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Metrics show whether a campaign works and where to fix it. Open rates are affected by Apple Mail privacy features, so click-based metrics are often more reliable.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Calculate open rate as unique opens divided by delivered emails.
2. Calculate click-through rate as unique clicks divided by delivered emails.
3. Calculate click-to-open rate as unique clicks divided by unique opens.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> 1,000 delivered, 250 unique opens, 40 unique clicks: open rate 25%, CTR 4%, CTOR 16%.

COMMON ERRORS

Comparing open rates between campaigns that used different send times or audiences.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between CTR and CTOR?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Calculate the metrics for three sample campaigns and say which one to repeat and why.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Trailhead: marketing basics

Module 2: Salesforce Ecosystem and Marketing Cloud Introduction

Level: Beginner. Where Marketing Cloud fits among the Salesforce clouds, and how the Engagement product, its business units and its studios are organised.

2.1 The Salesforce clouds

WHAT IS IT?

Salesforce sells several clouds: Sales Cloud (sales), Service Cloud (support), Marketing Cloud (marketing), Experience Cloud (portals), Data Cloud (unified customer data), Commerce Cloud (e-commerce) and the Salesforce Platform used to build apps.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

Projects often connect Marketing Cloud to Sales or Service Cloud data. Knowing each cloud's job tells you where the data should come from.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Name the cloud that owns the customer's order history, support tickets and marketing consent in a typical company.
2. Decide which cloud is the system of record for each.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

A retailer keeps orders in Commerce Cloud, support cases in Service Cloud, and sends campaigns from Marketing Cloud.

COMMON ERRORS

Treating Marketing Cloud as the master customer database when the CRM should own it.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Where does Marketing Cloud fit in the Salesforce ecosystem?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-paragraph description of each cloud and its main data.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce: product overview

Module 2

2.2 Marketing Cloud Engagement and related products (naming and licensing)

WHAT IS IT?

> Marketing Cloud Engagement is the product for email, mobile, journeys and automation. Other Salesforce marketing products include Marketing Cloud Personalization, Marketing Cloud Intelligence and editions such as Growth and Advanced. Feature availability depends on the edition and the licence on your account.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Product names and editions change. Promising a feature that your edition lacks causes project failure.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Confirm the product name and edition on the Salesforce product pages.
2. Check the account's licensed features in Setup before designing a solution.
3. Record which features need a specific licence.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A proposal that needs real-time web personalisation must confirm the Personalization product is licensed, not assume Engagement includes it.

Licence and edition: Verify current editions and licences on Salesforce pages before you commit to a design.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming every SFMC account has the same features.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you confirm what your account can do?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Make a table of five features and the product or edition that provides each, verified on official pages.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Marketing Cloud product pages

Module 3: SFMC Account Setup, Navigation and Administration

Level: Beginner. How an SFMC account is set up with business units, users, sender authentication and governance.

Module 3

3.1 Business units, the MID and account structure

WHAT IS IT?

> An SFMC account can hold an enterprise account with a parent business unit and child business units. Each business unit has its own MID (Marketing Cloud ID) and separate sending, data and assets, unless shared.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> The business unit design controls who sees which data and which sender domain is used. It is hard to change later, so design it first.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. List the brands or countries that need separate sending and data.
2. Create one child business unit per brand or country that needs isolation.
3. Decide which data extensions and assets are shared at parent level.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A group with two brands uses two child business units, each with its own sender profile and subscriber lists.

COMMON ERRORS

Creating too many business units, which splits data and makes reporting harder.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a business unit and why would you create one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw a business unit design for a company with three brands and one shared footer library.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 3

3.2 Users, roles, sender authentication and delivery settings

WHAT IS IT?

> Users get roles and permission sets that decide what they can do in each business unit. Sender authentication (SPF, DKIM, and a branded tracking domain where used) proves to mailbox providers that a sender is legitimate. Sender and delivery profiles hold the From name, address and reply settings.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Poor authentication causes emails to land in spam and damages the sending reputation of the whole account.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create users with the least permissions they need.
2. Set up sender authentication with the DNS records provided by SFMC.
3. Create a sender profile and a delivery profile for each brand.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Adding the DKIM record in DNS and checking it in SFMC before the first campaign.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending from a domain you have not authenticated.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does sender authentication protect against?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a checklist of the DNS records and the SFMC settings needed before the first send.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: sender authentication

Module 4: Contact Management and Data Architecture

Level: Beginner. Contacts, subscribers and keys, and how the data is modelled so that every message reaches the right person.

Module 4

4.1 Subscribers, contacts and keys

WHAT IS IT?

> A subscriber is a person in Email Studio, identified by a subscriber key. A contact is a person in Contact Builder, identified by a contact key, and one contact can own several subscribers (for example, one per email address or business unit). Subscriber keys must be unique and stable.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Wrong keys are the most common cause of duplicate emails and lost unsubscribes.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose a stable identifier (customer ID) as the subscriber key.
2. Never use the email address as the key if the address can change.
3. Check that the contact key matches the subscriber key in your model.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customer 10045 changes email address; the subscriber key stays 10045, so history and unsubscribes still apply.

COMMON ERRORS

Using email address as the key, then creating a new subscriber each time the address changes.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between a subscriber key and a contact key?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

List three possible subscriber key choices for a retailer and pick one with a reason.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 4

4.2 Data architecture: keys, relationships and data views

WHAT IS IT?

> Relational data uses primary keys (unique identifiers) and foreign keys (links to other tables). In SFMC, data extensions are the tables; relationships are modelled with keys and in Contact Builder.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A clear model avoids joins that multiply rows and produce wrong counts.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the primary key for each data extension.
2. Define the foreign key that links orders to customers.
3. Draw the relationship diagram before building.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customers (CustomerID primary) and Orders (OrderID primary, CustomerID foreign).

COMMON ERRORS

Joining on a non-unique field, which multiplies rows.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a primary key and why must it be unique?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the data model for customers, orders and products and label the keys.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 5: Data Extensions and Data Management

Level: Beginner. Data extensions: how they are created, imported, updated and kept clean.

Module 5

5.1 Creating and configuring data extensions

WHAT IS IT?

A data extension is an SFMC table. Types: standard, sendable (linked to a subscriber key and used for sends), non-sendable, and test. Each has fields with types, a primary key, nullable settings and retention settings.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

Choosing the right type and key decides whether the data can be used for sending and how long it stays.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create a data extension from the Email Studio or Contact Builder navigation.
2. Add fields with the right type (Text, Number, Date, Email, Phone, Boolean).
3. Set the primary key and make key fields non-nullable.
4. Set retention, for example delete all records after 365 days.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

A sendable data extension for customers with SubscriberKey as the send relationship field.

COMMON ERRORS

Choosing text for dates, so date filters fail.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a sendable data extension?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Create a customers data extension with five fields and a primary key in a sandbox account (or write the design if you have no account).

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 5

5.2 Importing, updating and cleaning data

WHAT IS IT?

> Data can be imported from CSV files, SFTP, Salesforce CRM, APIs and databases. Import options include overwrite, append, and update or insert on the primary key. Data quality checks catch duplicates, bad dates and missing keys.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Bad imports send emails to the wrong people. Validate before loading.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Prepare the CSV with a header row matching the field names.
2. Use the import activity with the update-or-insert option on the primary key.
3. Check row counts before and after the import.
4. Remove duplicates with a SQL query before the send.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Import 10,000 rows; the import reports 9,980 rows, so 20 rows had duplicate keys.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
-- Find duplicate keys before a send
SELECT SubscriberKey, COUNT(*) AS Copies
FROM Customers
GROUP BY SubscriberKey
HAVING COUNT(*) > 1;
```

COMMON ERRORS

Choosing overwrite when append was intended, and losing history.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you import daily customer updates without creating duplicates?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Import a sample CSV with planted duplicates and fix them with an import option and a SQL check.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: import data

Module 6: SQL for Salesforce Marketing Cloud

Level: Beginner to intermediate. SQL in SFMC: query activities, the supported syntax, aggregation, joins, data views and common audience queries.

Module 6

6.1 SQL fundamentals in SFMC

WHAT IS IT?

> SFMC SQL runs in Query Activities inside Automation Studio. It uses a T-SQL style syntax with some restrictions compared with SQL Server. Core clauses: SELECT, FROM, WHERE, GROUP BY, HAVING, ORDER BY.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Audiences, reports and suppression lists are almost always built with SQL in SFMC.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write the query in the Query Activity.
2. Set a target data extension and an update option (overwrite or append).
3. Run the activity, then check the row count in the target.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Select active customers from the Customers data extension into an Audience data extension.

COMMON ERRORS

Writing a query that works in SQL Server but is not supported in SFMC. Always test in the Query Activity.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a Query Activity?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a query that selects customers in one city and counts them.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC SQL reference (Salesforce docs)

6.2 Aggregation, joins and CTEs

WHAT IS IT?

> Aggregates (COUNT, SUM, AVG, MIN, MAX) with GROUP BY summarise data. JOIN combines data extensions and system data views. Common table expressions (WITH) name steps. Check the official SQL restrictions for the exact features your account supports.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Joins and aggregates produce segments and reports; a wrong join silently changes audience size.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use INNER JOIN when both sides must match.
2. Use LEFT JOIN to keep all customers and show missing orders as NULL.
3. Count distinct customers, not rows, when a customer has many orders.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customers with no order in 90 days: LEFT JOIN orders and keep rows where the order is NULL.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
-- Customers with no order in the last 90 days
SELECT c.SubscriberKey, c.EmailAddress
FROM Customers c
LEFT JOIN Orders o
  ON o.SubscriberKey = c.SubscriberKey
  AND o.OrderDate ⩾ DATEADD(day, -90, GETDATE())
WHERE o.OrderID IS NULL;
-- Line by line: LEFT JOIN keeps every customer; the date condition is inside the join so only
recent orders match;
-- WHERE o.OrderID IS NULL keeps customers with no matching recent order.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Counting rows where you need distinct customers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain the difference between INNER JOIN and LEFT JOIN.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the 90-day inactivity query and explain each line.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC SQL reference (Salesforce docs)

Module 6

6.3 SFMC data views

WHAT IS IT?

> System data views hold sends, opens, clicks, bounces, unsubscribes, jobs, journey activity and SMS tracking. Examples: _Subscribers, _Sent, _Open, _Click, _Bounce, _Unsubscribe, _Job, _Journey, _JourneyActivity, _SMSMessageTracking, _Complaint, _BusinessUnitUnsubscribes. Each has its own keys and retention limit.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Engagement analysis and suppression depend on these views. Retention limits mean old data may be gone, so keep your own history.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Check the view's documentation for keys and retention.
2. Join on SubscriberKey and JobID where the view supports them.
3. Export long-term history to your own data extension.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Last-open date per subscriber: SELECT SubscriberKey, MAX(EventDate) FROM _Open GROUP BY SubscriberKey.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming a data view keeps data forever.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is _Open used for and what limits apply?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

List the data views you would use for an engagement report and state each key and retention limit (verify on the docs).

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC data views (Salesforce docs)

Module 7: Email Studio

Level: Beginner to intermediate. Email Studio: sends, subscriber status, suppression and deliverability.

Module 7

7.1 Sends, classifications and subscriber status

WHAT IS IT?

> An email send is a definition with a data source, a send classification (commercial or transactional, depending on the law and consent), a sender profile and a delivery profile. Subscriber status includes active, unsubscribed, bounced and held.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Sending commercial email to unsubscribed people breaks the law in many places and damages reputation.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create the email, then the send definition.
2. Choose the send classification that matches the message (commercial needs consent and an unsubscribe link).
3. Use suppression lists for people who must not receive the message.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A password reset is transactional; a promotion is commercial with unsubscribe.

COMMON ERRORS

Using a commercial classification for transactional mail, or the reverse.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a send classification?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Classify five sample messages and explain each choice.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 7

7.2 Deliverability: SPF, DKIM, DMARC and bounce management

WHAT IS IT?

> SPF lists the servers allowed to send for a domain; DKIM signs messages; DMARC tells receivers what to do when checks fail. Bounces are hard (invalid address) or soft (temporary). Complaints and bounce rates affect reputation.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Good deliverability decides whether the message is seen at all.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Publish SPF and DKIM for the sending domain.
2. Add a DMARC policy starting with monitoring (p=none).
3. Remove hard-bounced addresses from the send.
4. Watch complaint rates after each send.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A hard bounce is suppressed automatically; a soft bounce is retried by the system.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending to old lists without removing bounces.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does DMARC do?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a deliverability checklist for a new sending domain.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Google: email sender guidelines

Module 8: Content Builder and Email Development

Level: Beginner to intermediate. Content Builder assets, responsive email design and dynamic content.

8.1 Content Builder assets and naming

WHAT IS IT?

> Content Builder stores emails, images, content blocks and templates in folders. Naming conventions make assets findable and safe to reuse.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Teams lose time looking for assets, and reused blocks change without warning if the naming and sharing are wrong.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create folders by brand, campaign type and year.
2. Name blocks with a prefix such as blk_footer_brandA.
3. Use shared content blocks for footers and legal text.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> blk_footer_brandA is used in 40 emails; one edit updates them all.

COMMON ERRORS

Editing a shared block without checking every email that uses it.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you organise Content Builder for three brands?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a folder and naming structure for two brands.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

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8.2 Responsive HTML email

WHAT IS IT?

Email HTML uses table-based layouts, inline CSS and media queries for mobile. Email clients have different support, so test in several clients.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

Most emails are opened on phones; a layout that breaks on mobile loses clicks.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use a single-column table layout with a maximum width of 600px.
2. Inline the key styles.
3. Use alt text on images and a text fallback for buttons.
4. Test on mobile and desktop clients.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

A two-column layout collapses to one column below 480px using a media query.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body style="margin:0;background:#f4f4f7;font-family:Arial,sans-serif">
<table role="presentation" width="100%" cellpadding="0" cellspacing="0"><tr><td align="center">
  <table role="presentation" width="600" style="max-width:600px;background:#ffffff">
    <tr><td style="padding:24px;text-align:center;font-size:22px;font-
weight:bold;color:#2b1a66">Your new offers</td></tr>
    <tr><td style="padding:0 24px 24px;font-size:16px;color:#1d1b2e">
      Hi %%=ProperCase(AttributeValue("FirstName"))=%%, here are picks for you.
    </td></tr>
    <tr><td align="center" style="padding:0 24px 32px">
      <a href="https://example.com/offer" style="background:#5b37c9;color:#ffffff;padding:12px
22px;text-decoration:none;border-radius:6px">See offers</a>
    </td></tr>
  </table>
</td></tr></table>
</body>
</html>
```

COMMON ERRORS

Relying on CSS features that many clients ignore.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Why are email layouts built with tables?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a 600px responsive promotional email with a header, hero, two columns and a button.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Campaign Monitor: HTML email guide

Module 9: AMPscript Programming

Level: Intermediate. AMPscript: syntax, variables, personalisation, data extension lookups and debugging.

Module 9

9.1 Syntax, variables and personalisation

WHAT IS IT?

> AMPscript runs on the server inside %%[...]%% blocks and prints values with %%=...=%%. SET assigns a variable; AttributeValue reads a subscriber attribute; ProperCase formats names.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Almost every personalised SFMC email or CloudPage uses AMPscript.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Declare with VAR and assign with SET.
2. Print with %%= ... =%%.
3. Use AttributeValue for subscriber fields and provide a default in IIF or a check.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Hello %%=ProperCase(AttributeValue("FirstName"))=%%.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
%%[
  VAR @first, @greeting
  SET @first = AttributeValue("FirstName")
  IF Empty(@first) THEN
    SET @greeting = "there"
  ELSE
    SET @greeting = ProperCase(@first)
  ENDIF
]%%
Hello %%=v(@greeting)=%%,
// Line by line: VAR declares the variables; SET reads the subscriber's first name;
// IF/ELSE chooses the fallback when the field is empty; v() prints the variable.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Printing an empty first name, which shows 'Hello ,'.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does AttributeValue return if the attribute is missing?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a greeting that falls back to 'there' if FirstName is empty.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 9

9.2 Data extension lookups

WHAT IS IT?

> Lookup returns one value from a data extension by matching a field. LookupRows returns a set of rows. RowCount counts them. Always handle the case when nothing is found.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Lookups personalise messages from other data (orders, loyalty points) without a separate send.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use Lookup('DataExtension','ReturnField','MatchField',value).
2. Check RowCount on LookupRows before looping.
3. Use the subscriber key or email address as the match value.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Show the loyalty points for the subscriber's email.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
%%[
  VAR @tier
  SET @tier = Lookup("LoyaltyMembers", "Tier", "EmailAddress", emailaddr)
  IF Empty(@tier) THEN SET @tier = "Member" ENDIF
]%%
Your tier: %%=v(@tier)=%%
// Lookup matches EmailAddress to the subscriber email (emailaddr); if no row, @tier is empty and
the default is used.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Lookup on a field that is not unique and returns a random row.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain Lookup and LookupRows.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Show the loyalty tier with a Lookup and a default when no row exists.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 10: HTML, CSS and JavaScript for SFMC

Level: Beginner to intermediate. The web basics needed for emails and CloudPages, and where JavaScript is used in SFMC.

Module 10

10.1 HTML and CSS essentials for SFMC

WHAT IS IT?

> HTML gives structure (headings, paragraphs, links, images, tables, forms). CSS gives style (colours, spacing, fonts). In email, styles must be inlined and tables used for layout.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> You cannot fix a broken email or landing page without these basics.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Learn tags: h1, p, a, img, table, tr, td.
2. Learn selectors and properties.
3. Inline styles for email clients.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A link is an a tag with an href attribute.

COMMON ERRORS

Using div-based layouts in email.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between HTML and CSS?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a simple page with a heading, a paragraph and a link.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- MDN: HTML basics (official)

Module 10

10.2 JavaScript in CloudPages and forms

WHAT IS IT?

> JavaScript runs in the browser and can validate forms. Server-side JavaScript (SSJS) runs in SFMC for data work and is different from browser JavaScript. Keep secrets off the browser.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Forms and interactive pages need validation before data is saved.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Validate the email format before submit.
2. Show error messages next to fields.
3. Use SSJS only where the platform supports it and check the docs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A registration form that checks the email format before posting.

COMMON ERRORS

Trusting browser validation alone; always validate on the server too.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Where would you run JavaScript in an SFMC project?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a browser check for an email field.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 11: Journey Builder

Level: Intermediate. Journeys: entry sources, activities, splits, testing and troubleshooting.

11.1 Entry sources and activities

WHAT IS IT?

> A journey starts with an entry source (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience) and moves contacts through activities: email, SMS, push, wait, decision splits, engagement splits, random splits and update contact.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Journeys deliver the multi-step experiences customers expect, from welcome series to renewal reminders.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose an entry source that updates in near real time for triggered journeys.
2. Add an email activity and a wait activity.
3. Add a decision split on a data field (for example, plan type).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Welcome journey: entry on sign-up, welcome email, wait 2 days, decision split on first login.

COMMON ERRORS

Entering contacts from a data extension that is refreshed once a week and expecting real-time triggers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an entry source and how do you choose one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a three-step welcome journey on paper with entry, email, wait and a split.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Journey Builder documentation (Salesforce)

Module 11

11.2 Re-entry, exit criteria and testing

WHAT IS IT?

> Re-entry rules decide whether a contact can enter again. Exit criteria stop contacts who have completed or unsubscribed. Test with a test data extension before activating.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A wrong re-entry rule either floods a contact with messages or stops them from ever re-entering.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Set re-entry rules explicitly.
2. Add an exit on unsubscribe.
3. Test with a small test population, then review contact tracking.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Abandoned cart: re-entry allowed after 7 days, exit when the order completes.

COMMON ERRORS

Leaving re-entry at default without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot a journey that does not accept contacts?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the test plan for an abandoned cart journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 12: Automation Studio

Level: Intermediate. Automations: SQL activities, file imports, scheduling and monitoring.

12.1 Activities and scheduling

WHAT IS IT?

> An automation is a sequence of activities such as SQL Query, Data Extract, File Transfer, Import File, Filter, Script, Verification and send activities, run on a schedule or on file arrival.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Automations prepare audiences and keep data current without manual work.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create the automation, add a SQL Query Activity, then a Data Extract if needed.
2. Set a schedule (daily at 02:00 for example).
3. Run once manually before scheduling.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Daily: import file, run audience query, filter, then send.

COMMON ERRORS

Scheduling before testing the SQL; failures then happen unattended.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you schedule a daily audience build?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Plan an automation with four activities and an order.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 12

12.2 Monitoring, errors and retries

WHAT IS IT?

> Automation status shows which activity failed. Verification activities check files or row counts before the next step. Failure notifications and logs help support teams.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Production failures need fast detection and a clear path back to working data.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Add a verification step after each import.
2. Set failure notifications to the owner.
3. Keep a rerun procedure.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A verification step stops the send if the file has fewer than 1,000 rows.

COMMON ERRORS

No row-count checks, so an empty file sends an empty campaign.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot an automation failure?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a runbook for a failed daily import.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 13: Contact Builder and Data Designer

Level: Intermediate. Contact Builder: attribute groups, relationships and the contact model.

13.1 Attribute groups and relationships

WHAT IS IT?

> Attribute groups bring fields from several data extensions into one contact view. One-to-one and one-to-many relationships link them through contact keys.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A clear contact model is the base of multi-business-unit and Customer 360 designs.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create an attribute group from the contact's data extensions.
2. Link tables with the contact key.
3. Check that one contact returns one row per attribute group where expected.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Contact (1) to orders (many): an attribute group for orders shows the most recent order fields.

COMMON ERRORS

Joining one-to-many data and expecting one row per contact.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an attribute group?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Model a customer with orders and loyalty tables in an attribute group design.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 13

13.2 Contact governance and deletion

WHAT IS IT?

> Contact deletion and retention decide how long personal data is kept. Governance records who owns the model and who may change it.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Retention is a legal requirement in many regions.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define retention per data extension.
2. Document contact deletion requests.
3. Review the contact model yearly.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A deletion request removes the contact and its linked records within the agreed time.

COMMON ERRORS

Keeping personal data forever.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you handle a deletion request in SFMC?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a deletion procedure for a privacy request.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 14: Mobile Studio and SMS Marketing

Level: Intermediate. MobileConnect for SMS and MobilePush for app notifications, with opt-in and compliance.

14.1 SMS and MobileConnect

WHAT IS IT?

> MobileConnect sends SMS. Keywords such as START and STOP handle opt-in and opt-out. Sender type (short code or long code) depends on the country and the account.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> SMS is strict on consent and frequency; mistakes lead to blocked messages and fines.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Record opt-in with a keyword or a form.
2. Send only to opted-in mobile numbers.
3. Include the opt-out instruction.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Text START to subscribe; reply STOP to unsubscribe, which is recorded automatically.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending SMS to numbers without consent.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you handle opt-out for SMS?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the opt-in and opt-out messages for a retail SMS programme.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: MobileConnect (verify current docs)

Module 14

14.2 MobilePush and compliance

WHAT IS IT?

> MobilePush sends notifications to mobile apps that register devices. Compliance covers consent, quiet hours, frequency and local messaging rules.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Notifications without consent or at night lose users.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Register devices with the app.
2. Target by segment.
3. Respect quiet hours and frequency caps.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A push at 10:00 local time for an opted-in user.

COMMON ERRORS

Ignoring the local rules for messages.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What checks apply before sending an SMS campaign?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a compliance checklist for SMS and push.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 15: CloudPages and Landing Page Development

Level: Intermediate. CloudPages: landing pages, forms, data capture and secure processing.

15.1 Building a registration page

WHAT IS IT?

> CloudPages are hosted pages built with HTML, CSS and AMPscript. A form posts data to a page that writes it to a data extension.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Lead capture and preference centres run on CloudPages.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Build the form with the required fields.
2. Read RequestParameter values on the page.
3. Write them to a data extension with UpsertDE.
4. Show a success or error message.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A newsletter sign-up writes the email to the Subscribers list.

COMMON ERRORS

Writing duplicate rows because the page never checks for an existing key.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you capture form data in CloudPages?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a newsletter sign-up page that writes to a data extension and handles duplicates.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- CloudPages documentation (Salesforce docs)

Module 15

15.2 Secure data capture and redirects

WHAT IS IT?

> Protect data by validating input, avoiding sensitive data in URLs and redirecting after success. Use RequestParameter and QueryParameter carefully.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Personal data in URLs ends up in logs and browser history.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Validate each field server-side.
2. Redirect after a successful post to avoid re-submits.
3. Do not put personal data in URLs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> After submit, redirect to a thank-you page.

COMMON ERRORS

Accepting any input without checks.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you protect customer information on a form?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Add validation and a redirect to the registration page.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 16: Marketing Cloud Personalization

Level: Intermediate. Personalisation concepts and the current Marketing Cloud Personalization product, distinguished from legacy naming.

Module 16

16.1 Personalisation concepts and product naming

WHAT IS IT?

> Personalisation shows each visitor the content that fits their profile and behaviour. Marketing Cloud Personalization is the current Salesforce product for real-time web and app personalisation; older material may call it Interaction Studio.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Clear product names avoid buying or building the wrong capability.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Confirm the product and its licence.
2. Map the data sources the product needs.
3. Define one measurable goal per experience.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A product page shows recommended items based on past browsing.

COMMON ERRORS

Using old Interaction Studio material for current features without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How does personalisation differ from segmentation?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-page personalisation brief with one goal and its data sources.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce product pages (verify current naming)

Module 17: Marketing Cloud Intelligence and Analytics

Level: Intermediate. Campaign analytics, cross-channel reporting and the Intelligence product.

Module 17

17.1 Campaign analytics and attribution

WHAT IS IT?

> Analytics measure open, click, conversion and revenue by campaign and channel. Attribution assigns credit to channels. Intelligence connects data from many sources for cross-channel reporting.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Budget decisions depend on which channels create revenue.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the revenue and conversion events.
2. Map campaign IDs consistently.
3. Build a dashboard with one page per question.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Email revenue per campaign: sum of orders attributed to each send within seven days.

COMMON ERRORS

Comparing channels with different attribution windows.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you measure campaign ROI?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Calculate ROI for three campaigns with stated assumptions.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Marketing Cloud Intelligence docs (verify current product)

Module 18: SFMC APIs and Integrations

Level: Advanced. REST and SOAP APIs, installed packages, OAuth, and integration patterns with Salesforce and other systems.

18.1 REST authentication with an installed package

WHAT IS IT?

> An installed package in SFMC gives an app a client ID and secret. The app requests an access token from the account's auth endpoint, then calls REST endpoints with the token. Token requests use your account subdomain.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Every integration starts with authentication; mistakes cause 401 errors and leaked credentials.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create an installed package with the required API permissions.
2. Copy the client ID, secret and subdomain (store them in a secrets manager).
3. Request a token and call one endpoint.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> POST to the token endpoint, then GET a data extension list with the bearer token.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
# Token request (replace the subdomain and credentials; never commit them)
curl -X POST "https://YOUR_SUBDOMAIN.auth.marketingcloudapis.com/v2/token" \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{"grant_type":"client_credentials","client_id":"YOUR_ID","client_secret":"YOUR_SECRET"}'
# The response contains access_token. Use it as: Authorization: Bearer <access_token>
```

COMMON ERRORS

Putting the client secret in front-end code.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain how OAuth works in an SFMC integration.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Authenticate with a sandbox account and list data extensions with Postman.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Marketing Cloud REST and SOAP API docs

Module 18

18.2 REST versus SOAP and common patterns

WHAT IS IT?

> REST uses JSON over HTTP and is the recommended approach for new work. SOAP uses XML and WSDL and remains available for some legacy operations. Patterns: create triggered sends, upsert contacts, read tracking data, manage assets.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Choosing the right API avoids rework; REST is simpler to test.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use REST for new integrations.
2. Check the docs for each operation's rate limits.
3. Log every request and response status.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Triggered send: POST with the subscriber, the email definition and personalisation attributes.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending bulk data one record at a time instead of using batch endpoints.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

REST versus SOAP: which would you use and why?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Describe a triggered-send integration with request, response and error handling.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 19: Salesforce Data Cloud and Marketing Cloud Integration

Level: Advanced. Data Cloud concepts and how unified profiles reach Marketing Cloud for activation.

Module 19

19.1 Data Cloud concepts

WHAT IS IT?

> Data Cloud ingests data from many sources, resolves identities into unified profiles, and makes segments and calculated insights available for activation, including to Marketing Cloud. Naming and licensing change; check current Salesforce documentation.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Enterprise Customer 360 projects depend on unified profiles.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Map sources to data streams.
2. Define identity resolution rules.
3. Build a segment and activate it to Marketing Cloud.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Web events and CRM records unified into one profile; the segment 'recent buyers' activates to a journey.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming Data Cloud is included with Marketing Cloud Engagement.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is identity resolution?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the data flow from three sources to one activated segment.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Data Cloud documentation (verify)

Module 20: Advanced Marketing Automation and Personalisation

Level: Advanced. Event-driven and lifecycle automation, advanced segmentation and optimisation.

Module 20

20.1 Lifecycle automation and optimisation

WHAT IS IT?

> Lifecycle automation runs journeys on events (sign-up, purchase, lapse). Optimisation tests variants, frequency and send times, measuring the results with control groups.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Automated lifecycle programmes compound revenue and retention.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the lifecycle events.
2. Create a control group to measure lift.
3. Test one variable at a time.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Win-back journey with a 10% holdout to measure incremental revenue.

COMMON ERRORS

Declaring success without a control group.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you measure a journey's incremental impact?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a win-back test with a holdout and a success metric.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 21: SFMC Security, Privacy and Deliverability

Level: Advanced. Access control, consent, deliverability and compliance with data protection laws.

Module 21

21.1 Security and access

WHAT IS IT?

> Access control uses roles, permission sets and business-unit access. API credentials need least privilege and rotation. Audit trails record changes.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Breaches usually come from over-broad access or leaked credentials.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Review roles every quarter.
2. Rotate API secrets.
3. Keep audit logs on.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A campaign manager cannot export the full customer table.

COMMON ERRORS

Sharing one admin login between people.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you control access in an SFMC account?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write an access review checklist.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 21

21.2 Privacy and compliance

WHAT IS IT?

> GDPR (EU) and India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act set rules for consent, minimisation, access and deletion. CAN-SPAM (US) and CASL (Canada) set email rules. Check the rules that apply to each audience.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Non-compliance leads to fines and blocked sends.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Record consent and its source.
2. Honour unsubscribes immediately.
3. Keep data only as long as needed.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A consent flag in the contact model controls which journeys a person may enter.

COMMON ERRORS

Treating consent as one checkbox for every channel.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do GDPR and DPDP affect marketing data?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a consent model for email and SMS.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- GDPR text (official EU)
- MeitY: DPDP framework (official)

Module 22: SFMC Testing, Troubleshooting and Performance

Level: Advanced. Testing campaigns and integrations, troubleshooting failures and tuning performance.

Module 22

22.1 Testing and troubleshooting

WHAT IS IT?

> Test email previews, personalisation, links, journeys with test contacts, automations on sample data, SQL on small populations and APIs with sandbox calls. Troubleshooting follows the error, the logs and recent changes.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Most production incidents are preventable with a test plan.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Send tests to seed addresses.
2. Check each personalisation with a missing value.
3. Run SQL on a sample before a full run.
4. Keep a runbook.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A seed-list test shows a broken personalisation before the real send.

COMMON ERRORS

Testing only with one perfect record.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you investigate a failed email send?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Create a test plan for a welcome email and journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 23: SFMC Architecture and Enterprise Implementation

Level: Advanced. Architecture decisions for multi-business-unit programmes and how to document them.

Module 23

23.1 Multi-business-unit architecture

WHAT IS IT?

> Decide what is shared at parent level (footers, compliance text, reference data) and what is isolated per business unit (sender, subscribers, data). Document each decision.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Architecture choices decide governance, cost and how easily brands can change.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write requirements (functional and non-functional).
2. Draw the business unit and data diagram.
3. Record decisions as ADRs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Shared reference data at parent; brand subscribers isolated in child business units.

COMMON ERRORS

Sharing subscriber data across brands without a legal basis.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Design a multi-business-unit SFMC solution.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-page architecture for two brands with one shared footer library.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- C4 model (diagrams)

Module 24: AI in Marketing Cloud and Intelligent Automation

Level: Advanced. AI features in marketing automation, with product names and licences checked on official pages, and AI integration with APIs.

Module 24

24.1 AI for campaigns and analytics

WHAT IS IT?

> AI can draft subject lines and copy, suggest segments, predict churn and recommend next actions. Salesforce AI capabilities are offered under specific product and licence names; verify before promising them.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> AI speeds up content work but needs human approval and tested outputs.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use AI to draft, a human to approve.
2. Test generated copy for compliance and brand rules.
3. Measure lift against the control group.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> AI drafts three subject lines; the team tests two with a 10% split.

COMMON ERRORS

Publishing AI copy without review.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you use AI safely in a campaign workflow?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design an AI copy workflow with human approval steps.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce AI overview (verify)

Module 24

24.2 Integrating an external AI model

WHAT IS IT?

> An integration sends campaign data to an AI model API and writes the result back to a data extension. Keep personal data minimal and never send secrets to a model.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> External models are useful when a feature is not in the SFMC licence.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Send only the fields the model needs.
2. Store the output in a review table.
3. Log model version and cost.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A monthly churn score is written to a data extension, then used in a journey split.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending full customer records to a third-party model.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you add an AI score to a journey safely?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design the data flow for a churn-score integration with privacy controls.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Anthropic: API docs
- OpenAI: API docs

Module 25: Practical Labs and Real-World Scenarios

Level: All levels. Twenty step-by-step labs. Some need a provisioned SFMC account; others are simulated or can be done on paper.

Module 25

25.1 How to use the labs

WHAT IS IT?

> Each lab lists the objective, scenario, prerequisites, tools, dataset, steps, code, expected output, validation, common errors and assessment. Labs marked 'account' need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account; labs marked 'simulated' can be done with sample files and paper.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Practice on real data builds the skill employers test for.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Check the lab's requirement tag first.
2. Work in a sandbox or test business unit.
3. Keep a log of errors and fixes.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Lab 4: import and clean customer records (account required).

COMMON ERRORS

Practising in production.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you practise SFMC without a paid account?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Pick one simulated lab and complete it on sample files.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 26: Capstone Projects and Portfolio

Level: Advanced. Eight capstone projects with requirements, architecture, code, testing and demo evidence.

Module 26

26.1 Portfolio standard

WHAT IS IT?

> Each project includes business problem, users, scope, requirements, architecture, data model, data flow, steps, SQL and AMPscript code, testing, evidence, KPIs, impact, limitations, future work, documentation and a demo video.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A portfolio with evidence gets interviews; a list of tools does not.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write the business problem first.
2. Build and test each part.
3. Record a 3-minute demo.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Project 3: abandoned cart automation with SQL segments and a multi-channel follow-up.

COMMON ERRORS

Showing screenshots with no explanation.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does a strong SFMC portfolio project include?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Choose one of the eight projects and write its requirements.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 27: SFMC Interview Preparation and Career Readiness

Level: All levels. Technical, scenario and behavioural interviews for SFMC roles, with a question bank and practice plan.

Module 27

27.1 Interview readiness

WHAT IS IT?

> Interviews test SQL, AMPscript, journeys, automations, APIs, architecture and troubleshooting. Practise by explaining your own projects with results.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Hiring managers look for evidence of production work and clear reasoning.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Practise 20 SQL questions and 10 AMPscript exercises.
2. Prepare two project stories with results.
3. Do two mock interviews a week.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Scenario: a high bounce rate. Investigate by list source, hard versus soft bounce, domain, timing and sender reputation.

COMMON ERRORS

Answering without a method.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

A campaign has a high bounce rate. How do you investigate?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Answer the eight scenario questions out loud and record yourself.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Interview bank: see the Interview Preparation Handbook

Module 28: Certification Preparation and Learning Roadmap

Level: All levels. How to prepare for Salesforce certifications and a realistic 12-month plan. Certification names must be checked on Trailhead before you register.

Module 28

28.1 Certifications and the roadmap

WHAT IS IT?

> Salesforce certifications change over time. Check the official Trailhead credentials catalogue for active names, prerequisites, exam objectives and weighting. The roadmap in this academy gives a 12-month study plan.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A current, recognised certification helps screening, but experience matters more.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Open the official credentials list on Trailhead and note active names.
2. Read the exam guide for the one you choose.
3. Follow the 12-month roadmap.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Plan: months 1 to 3 fundamentals; months 4 to 8 applied labs; months 9 to 12 projects and exam.

COMMON ERRORS

Registering before the exam guide is read.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you prepare for an SFMC certification?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write your own 12-month plan using the template.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Trailhead credentials (official)

Practical labs (Module 25)

Each lab lists the objective, scenario, prerequisites, tools, dataset, steps, code, expected output, validation, common errors and assessment in the full lab workbook (next batch). Use this list to plan.

Lab	Title	Requirement
Lab 1	Create a basic SFMC account and understand the environment	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 2	Design an enterprise business unit structure	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 3	Create a customer data extension	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 4	Import and clean customer records	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 5	Write SQL segmentation queries	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 6	Create an email template	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 7	Build a personalised email using AMPscript	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 8	Create a dynamic content email	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 9	Build a welcome journey	Needs a provisioned SFMC account

Lab 10	Create an abandoned cart journey	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 11	Build a customer retention automation	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 12	Create a scheduled SQL automation	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 13	Build a CloudPage registration form	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 14	Integrate SFMC using REST APIs	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 15	Create an API-triggered email	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 16	Build an SMS customer notification	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 17	Create a marketing performance dashboard	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 18	Integrate Salesforce CRM data	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 19	Design a Customer 360 activation workflow	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 20	Develop an AI-assisted marketing automation workflow	Simulated or paper practice